The Mad Alchemist

A Tier 1 Adventure

For the Ashen Role-Playing Game

1

INTRODUCTION

What this adventure is about

Contents

Introduction . . . 2
- Adventure Summary . . . 2
- How to Use This Document . . . 2
- Adventure Synopsis . . . 3
- Player Hooks . . . 3
- Session Overview . . . 3
- XP and Wealth Budget . . . 3
- NPC Quick Reference . . . 4

Keshto Village . . . 5
First Visit — The Investigation . . . 5
- The Briefing . . . 5
- Investigation Leads . . . 5
- Clue Tracker . . . 7

Return to Keshto — The Mortefactor Connection . . . 7
- Merzaghaal Revisited . . . 7
- The Mortefactor Tracker . . . 7
- A Local Who Remembers (Second Chance) . . . 7
- Putting It Together . . . 8
- The Moral Question . . . 8

The Dump Site . . . 9
- Getting There . . . 9
- The Scene . . . 9
- Investigating the Scene . . . 10
- Field Encounter . . . 10
- Hazard: Soul Residue . . . 11

The Ritual Site . . . 12
- Getting There . . . 12
- The Scene . . . 12
- Investigating the Scene . . . 12

The Faerie Ruin . . . 14
- Layer 1: Getting In . . . 14
- Layer 2: The Undead Sentries . . . 14
- Layer 3: Fey Illusions and Barriers . . . 15
- Layer 4: The Alchemical Monstrosity . . . 15
- Layer 5: Šauhahten . . . 16
- Aftermath . . . 18

Appendix . . . 19
- Bestiary . . . 19
- Skill Check Reference . . . 19
- Loot Table . . . 20
- XP Summary . . . 21
- Clue Flowchart . . . 21
- Open Threads . . . 21

Adventure Summary

The Mad Alchemist is a Tier 1 adventure for the Ashen role-playing game, designed for a party of four characters and approximately eight sessions of play. It is written with a first-time Game Master in mind: every mechanical element is explained, every decision point is flagged, and the structure rewards preparation without punishing improvisation.

For the Game Master: This adventure assumes you have read the core rulebook, but it does not assume you have run a game before. Where the adventure asks you to make a judgement call, it tells you what factors to weigh. Where it presents a skill check, it tells you what the result means. Trust the structure, and trust your players.

How to Use This Document

This adventure uses several formatting conventions to help you find information quickly during play:

Text in this style is meant to be read aloud or paraphrased to your players. It sets a scene, describes what the characters see, or delivers an NPC's words. You do not need to read it verbatim — use it as a starting point and make it your own.

Text in this style is a note for you, the Game Master. It provides context, tactical advice, or guidance on how to handle a situation. Your players should not see this information unless you choose to share it.

Text in this style flags something important — a common pitfall, a design intention you should not undermine, or a moment that requires careful handling. Read these before the session in which they appear.

Skill checks are noted inline as **Skill DN** (e.g. **Occultism D3**), where the number is the difficulty. The result of the check — what information it yields or what happens on success — follows immediately.

Adventure Synopsis

The adventure takes place in and around Keshto Village, a frontier settlement in Venna Weald clear. People have been disappearing — foragers, patrols, travelers between settlements — and the disappearances are accelerating. The Never-Still have issued a Black Guard contract for Deathless willing to investigate.

The party's investigation leads them from the village into the wilds of the Weald's outskirts, where they discover two sites: a dump site where soulless corpses have been discarded, and a ritual site where the extractions are performed. The method is alchemical and scholarly — Mortefactor-derived, though twisted beyond what the faction would condone.

Returning to Keshto with this evidence, the party connects with a Mortefactor tracker who has been quietly hunting the culprit: Šauhahten, a Mirror expelled from the Most Ancient and Noble Order of Mortefactors for experimenting on souls. He is attempting to create Prima Materia — the pinnacle of alchemy — by rendering down mortal souls, guided by a voice in the Fog whose true nature he does not understand.

Armed with the alchemist's identity and the location of his laboratory — hidden beneath an ancient Faerie ruin the party may have already visited — the party descends into a layered dungeon defended by reanimated victims, fey illusions, and an alchemical monstrosity. At the heart of it, they confront Šauhahten himself: calm, articulate, and utterly certain that his murders are necessary to heal the world.

The party's victory lies in destroying the laboratory and its research, setting Šauhahten back by years or decades. He cannot be permanently killed — he is Deathless, and will reincorporate at his soul anchor. The adventure ends with a victory and an open threat, ready to seed future adventures.

Player Hooks

Why is your character in Keshto Village, answering a Black Guard contract?

- **Never-Still member:** You were sent by the faction leadership. Never-Still peacekeepers are among the missing, and there is an old Faerie site nearby that the faction considers significant. This is faction business.
- **Free Agent:** You are here for the coin and the reputation. Black Guard contracts pay well, and completing one builds your name.
- **Other faction member:** Your faction sent you here for reasons that may not be entirely transparent. Perhaps they have heard rumours of Mortefactor research being misused. Perhaps they simply want eyes on the situation.

Session Overview

SESSION OVERVIEW

Session	Location	Focus	System Lessons
1–2	Keshto Village	Social investigation, gathering leads	Social interaction, skill checks
3–4	Dump Site, Ritual Site	Field exploration, crime scene investigation	Exploration, hazards, Fog, first combat
5	Keshto Village	Faction politics, assembling the picture	Social negotiation, faction dynamics
6–8	The Faerie Ruin	Dungeon, combat, climax	Combat, puzzles, threat assessment, Deathless

XP and Wealth Budget

EXPECTED XP PER CHARACTER

Source	XP
Combat (field encounters)	15–30
Combat (undead sentries)	28–42
Combat / bypass (monstrosity)	25
Combat (Šauhahten)	60
Mission XP (primary: destroy laboratory)	100
Mission XP (secondary, optional)	100
Loot XP (estimated)	50–100
Total	**378–457**

Over eight sessions, characters should earn roughly 1500–2000 XP total (including XP from sources not itemised above, such as incidental encounters and additional loot). Combined with the 1000 XP every character starts with, this puts the party at approximately 2500–3000 cumulative XP by the end of the adventure — ready to begin purchasing Tier 2 advances.

EXPECTED WEALTH PER CHARACTER

Source	Feathers
Black Guard contract payout	500–1000
Field site salvage	100–200
Laboratory salvage	300–600
Total income	**900–1800**
Maintenance costs (est. 2–3 intermissions)	200–600
Net wealth	**300–1200**

NPC Quick Reference

NPCS

Name	Race	Faction	Role	Location
Merzaghaal	Goldenbristle	Never-Still	Quest-giver, faction contact	Keshto
The Town Reeve	TBD	–	Local authority, disappearance records	Keshto
Surviving Peacekeeper	TBD	Never-Still	Bridge to field exploration	Keshto
Mortefactor Tracker	TBD	Mortefactors	Faction intel, cipher, tension	Keshto
Local Who Remembers	TBD	–	Personal details on Šauhahten	Keshto
Šauhahten	Mirror	Ex-Mortefactors	Villain	Faerie Ruin

2

KESHTO VILLAGE

The settlement in Venna Weald

First Visit — The Investigation

The adventure begins in Keshto Village, a frontier settlement in the Venna Weald clear. The party has arrived in response to a Black Guard contract issued by the Never-Still.

Keshto is small and practical — a cluster of stone and timber buildings around a market square, ringed by a low wall that marks the boundary between settlement and wilderness. The Weald presses close on all sides, ancient forest visible over the rooftops. The air smells of woodsmoke and rain.

The Briefing

The party's first contact is Merzaghaal, the Never-Still agent who issued the contract. He meets them at the village's only inn.

The Goldenbristle leans forward across the table, his bristled mane catching the lamplight. He speaks carefully, as if weighing each word against the cost of saying it.

"Thank you for coming. I will be direct. Over the past three months, eleven people have gone missing from the outskirts of this settlement. Six civilians — foragers, a trapper, a courier. Five of our peacekeepers, sent to investigate. None have returned. No bodies have been recovered.

"The disappearances cluster along the northeastern routes, where the Weald thins and the Fog gets thicker. They are accelerating — three in the last two weeks alone. I have put out a Black Guard contract because whatever is happening is beyond what local peacekeepers can handle.

"Your job is to find out what is taking these people and put a stop to it. I can provide what we know, introduce you to the people who know more, and offer the resources of this office. Payment on completion."

Merzaghaal

- **Race:** Goldenbristle (Sootbeast)
- **Faction:** Never-Still (mid-level agent)
- **Personality:** Competent, professional, dry. Cares about this as a faction matter first, a humanitarian crisis second. Not callous — simply prioritised. He will be frustrated if the party wastes time.
- **What he knows:** The timeline and geography of the disappearances. That the Faerie site northeast of Keshto has cultural significance to the Never-Still. That the peacekeepers who were sent were competent and should not have simply vanished.
- **What he does not know:** The cause of the disappearances. What is happening to the victims. Who is responsible.
- **What he can provide:** The contract briefing, introductions to the Town Reeve and the surviving peacekeeper, access to Never-Still records and supplies, and a sounding board when the party returns with new information.

Merzaghaal is the party's anchor NPC. He is not an adventurer and will not accompany them into the field, but he is always available in Keshto to discuss findings, broker introductions, and provide faction context. If the party is stuck, he can suggest next steps — but he should not solve their problems for them.

Investigation Leads

The party can pursue the following leads in any order. Each provides a piece of the puzzle; together, they give the party enough to head into the field.

The Town Reeve

- **Race:** TBD (mortal)
- **Personality:** Harried, worried, practical. The reeve has been dealing with panicked families and dwindling search parties for weeks. There may be tension with Merzaghaal — it took dead *peacekeepers* to get faction attention, and the reeve remembers the civilian disappearances that preceded them.
- **What the reeve provides:** The human cost of the disappearances. Names, dates, occupations, last known locations.

DISAPPEARANCES

Name	Occupation	Weeks Ago	Last Seen
Orin Vasek	Forager	11	Northeast trail, past the creek
Dara Millen	Trapper	9	Her trapline, northeast ridge
Josen Haal	Courier	8	Road to Ashmark, northeast fork
Three civilians	Various	6–4	Northeast outskirts
Two peacekeepers	Patrol	3	Northeast, investigating Vasek route
Three peacekeepers	Search party	2	Northeast, broader search
Pel Torren	Forager	1	Northeast, near the old shrine trail

- **Skill checks:**
  - **Investigate D2:** Review the records and build the timeline. The pattern is obvious: every victim was alone or in a small group, every disappearance is in the northeast, and the frequency is increasing.
  - **Influence D3:** The reeve opens up about the toll this has taken on the community. People are afraid to leave the village. The forager economy is suffering. The reeve is grateful someone is finally taking this seriously — or resentful that it took this long.

The Surviving Peacekeeper

- **Race:** TBD
- **Personality:** Shaken. He was part of the first two-person patrol sent to investigate. His partner vanished. He did not see what happened — one moment his partner was there, the next she was not. He found signs of a brief struggle but no body.
- **What he provides:** A specific location — the area where his partner disappeared, which is the party's starting point for finding the dump site and/or ritual site. He also provides an emotional anchor: the first taste of what the stakes feel like on a personal level.
- **Skill checks:**
  - **Influence D2:** Get him talking. He wants to help but is struggling with guilt and fear. A sympathetic approach works better than a demanding one.
  - **Awareness D3:** Notice that he is holding something back — not information, but emotion. His partner was more than a colleague. This is not plot-critical, but it adds weight to the stakes.

The peacekeeper's key function is to give the party a place to start looking. His directions should point them toward the general area where both the dump site and ritual site can be found — northeast of Keshto, where the Weald thins and the Fog thickens. Do not make the party roll to obtain this information. It is the minimum they need to proceed.

Early Faerie Site Visit

Merzaghaal may send the party to check the old Faerie shrine northeast of Keshto as a routine task: "Strange things are happening nearby. Go see if the old shrine has been disturbed."

The shrine is a clearing in the deep Weald, marked by standing stones overgrown with moss and creeping vines. The air hums faintly — not a sound, exactly, but a resonance you feel in your teeth. Whatever power this place once held has faded, but it has not entirely gone.

On this first visit, the surface level is exactly what it appears to be: ancient, overgrown, resonant with faded magic. The party finds nothing suspicious.

- **Occultism D5:** The character senses that the Faerie resonance here is unusually well-preserved — stronger than it should be for a ruin this old. This is flavour, not a clue. It becomes significant only in retrospect.
- **Investigate D6:** The character notices subtle signs that someone has been here recently — disturbed moss, a stone shifted slightly out of alignment. This DC is intentionally too high for most Tier 1 parties at this stage.

The shrine is the entrance to Šauhahten's laboratory, but the party should not discover this yet. The Investigate D6 is deliberately set above what a T1 party can reliably hit — it exists so that an exceptionally lucky or well-built character *might* get an early hint, but the adventure does not require it. If a character does succeed, give them a sense that someone has been here, but not enough to find the hidden entrance. That requires information from Phase 3.

A Local Who Remembers

A civilian in Keshto — a shopkeeper, a supplier — who interacted with Šauhahten before he withdrew to the outskirts.

- **Race:** TBD (mortal)
- **Personality:** Curious, not afraid. This person is not involved in the plot. They simply remember a remarkable customer. A Mirror is hard to forget in a frontier settlement.
- **Finding this NPC:** The party must ask around the village about unusual people in the area. **Investigate D3** to locate someone who remembers.
- **What they provide:** A description of Šauhahten — tall, Mirror features (the fey shimmer of an Echo), polite, spoke in measured sentences, asked unusual questions about local alchemical supplies and the properties of local Fog. Bought materials in bulk: glassware, reagents, heavy metal containers. Traveled northeast. Stopped coming to the village perhaps six months ago.

This NPC is optional in Phase 1. The party can find them now or in Phase 3 when they return with more specific questions. The information this NPC provides becomes much more valuable once the party knows they are looking for a Mirror alchemist. In Phase 1, it is a colour detail. In Phase 3, it is a confirmation.

Clue Tracker

By the end of Phase 1, the party should know:

- **Thread 1 (the facts):** People are disappearing. The pattern points northeast. The disappearances are accelerating.
- **Thread 2 (partial):** Something strange is happening — this is not a mundane predator or bandit.
- **A location:** The peacekeeper's directions, pointing them into the field.

If the party has this, they are ready for Phase 2. If they are missing the location, the peacekeeper provides it without a check — it is the minimum the adventure requires. Do not let the party get stuck in the village.

System lesson for this phase: Social interaction and skill checks. Let the players drive the conversation. Call for rolls only when the outcome is uncertain and failure has consequences. If a player asks the reeve for the disappearance timeline and the reeve has no reason to hide it, just give it to them — no roll required.

Return to Keshto — The Mortefactor Connection

The party returns to Keshto Village after exploring the dump site and ritual site. They have new evidence and specific questions: the method is Mortefactor-derived, the operation is sophisticated and scholarly, and the perpetrator is not at either field site.

Merzaghaal Revisited

With the party's new evidence, Merzaghaal's knowledge becomes more useful.

- **Influence D3:** Merzaghaal shares faction intelligence he might otherwise keep close. He has heard that an unaffiliated Deathless has been operating in the area — someone who does not belong to any faction he recognises. With the party's description of Mortefactor-derived techniques, the pieces click. He brokers an introduction to someone who can help.

The Mortefactor Tracker

A Deathless agent of the Most Ancient and Noble Order of Mortefactors, sent to quietly track Šauhahten after his expulsion. He has been in or around Keshto for some time, but lost the trail. The party's evidence from the ritual site is exactly what he has been looking for.

- **Race:** TBD (Deathless)
- **Faction:** The Most Ancient and Noble Order of Mortefactors
- **Personality:** Guarded, precise, cooperative but with an undercurrent of faction loyalty. He wants Šauhahten stopped, but he also wants the research recovered — not destroyed. He views the research as dangerous but valuable, and as stolen Mortefactor property.
- **How the party meets him:** Either Merzaghaal brokers the introduction, or the tracker approaches the party directly once he hears about their findings. He has been waiting for someone to bring him the evidence he needs.
- **What he provides:**
  - Šauhahten's name and the circumstances of his expulsion (advocating for or already conducting soul experiments)
  - Identification of the ritual techniques as Mortefactor-derived
  - Knowledge of what Prima Materia research requires: Fog proximity and ambient magical energy — exactly what an old Faerie site provides
  - A partial copy of the Faerie resonance cipher that Šauhahten stole when he left the order. This is the key to the laboratory entrance.
- **What he wants:**

The tracker wants the research recovered, not simply destroyed. He may frame this as a reasonable request — the Mortefactors can secure it, study it safely, ensure it does not fall into other hands. The party may agree, disagree, or negotiate. This tension should not derail the adventure, but it introduces faction politics at a manageable scale and creates a hook for future adventures.

If the party refuses, the tracker does not become an enemy. He is disappointed but pragmatic. If the party agrees, they may have made a promise they will want to revisit later.

- **Skill checks:**
  - **Awareness D4:** Notice that the tracker has his own agenda. He is helpful, but his helpfulness has a direction — toward recovering the research, not just stopping Šauhahten.
  - **Influence D4:** Negotiate the terms of cooperation. A strong result gives the party leverage: the tracker agrees to let them decide what happens to the research after the laboratory is dealt with.

A Local Who Remembers (Second Chance)

If the party did not find this NPC in Phase 1, they can find them now with an **Investigate D2** check (reduced from D3, because the party now has a specific description to ask about — a Mirror alchemist who bought unusual supplies).

The information is the same as in Phase 1, but it now has much more context. The supply routes and bulk purchases help narrow down the laboratory's location, confirming what the tracker's knowledge of Prima Materia requirements already suggests: the Faerie site.

Putting It Together

By the end of Phase 3, the party should know all four investigation threads:

- **Thread 1 (the facts):** People are disappearing. The operation is methodical and accelerating.
- **Thread 2 (the what):** Souls are being extracted using alchemical techniques. This is not necromancy, predation, or divine power.
- **Thread 3 (the who):** Šauhahten, a Mirror, expelled Mortefactor, operating alone. He is attempting to create Prima Materia.
- **Thread 4 (the where):** The laboratory is beneath the old Faerie shrine northeast of Keshto — the site the party may have already visited.

If the party has all four threads, they are ready for the climax. If they are missing Thread 4, the tracker's knowledge of Prima Materia requirements (Fog proximity + ambient magical energy) combined with the Faerie site's unusual resonance should point them there.

The Moral Question

Before the party enters the laboratory, consider: do they understand why Šauhahten is doing what he is doing? The tracker should have explained that Prima Materia is the alchemical pinnacle — a substance that, in theory, could restart the broken cycle of death and rebirth. Šauhahten believes he is saving the world.

This matters because the party will have a chance to speak with Šauhahten before fighting him, and his argument is genuinely compelling if you do not think too hard about the screaming. Prepare for the possibility that your players might hesitate, argue among themselves, or even consider agreeing with him. That is good — it means the adventure is working. See the Faerie Ruin chapter for guidance on handling this moment.

3

THE DUMP SITE

Where the bodies are left

The dump site is where Šauhahten disposes of the bodies after extracting their souls. It is one of two field locations the party can discover during exploration; the other is the ritual site. They can be found in either order — finding one makes finding the other easier, as trails connect them.

Getting There

The surviving peacekeeper's directions point the party northeast of Keshto, into the thinning Weald where the Fog boundary draws close. The journey takes the better part of a day on foot — long enough to feel the transition from settled land to wilderness.

The forest changes as you move northeast. The canopy thins. The underbrush grows sparser but stranger — pale shoots, fungi that should not grow this far from the Fog. The birdsong stops before you notice it has stopped. The air takes on a faint chemical tang that does not belong to any forest.

Fog exposure: The dump site is near the Fog boundary. The party is not yet in Dense Fog, but the proximity should be felt — strange growth, unusual silence, the occasional wisp of Fog curling between the trees. If any mortal party members are present, note that prolonged exposure in this area is unpleasant but not yet mechanically dangerous. The ritual site is closer to the Fog and may trigger exposure rules.

The peacekeeper's directions give the party the right *area*, not the right *location*. The ravine is screened by deadfall and brush — it does not announce itself. Finding it requires tracking through the thinning Weald, reading the terrain, and following the signs of repeated passage.

Running the Tracking Challenge

The party makes a series of group checks to locate the dump site. Each stretch represents a section of the Weald that must be searched or reasoned through.

Number of stretches: Start with 2. Each failed check adds 1 additional stretch (to a maximum of 3 total). Each successful check reduces the remaining stretches by 1.

Available checks (each stretch, choose one):

- **Awareness D3:** Read the terrain — broken branches at a consistent height, undergrowth trampled in a line, pale fungi that cluster along a path of disturbed soil. Something has passed this way many times.
- **Investigate D3:** Reason out the disposal logic. The perpetrator needs a location screened from casual observation, far enough from Keshto to avoid discovery, accessible from a specific direction, and near the Fog boundary for cover. That narrows the search to ravines and depressions in a specific corridor of the Weald.
- **Stamina D4:** The terrain is rough and the Fog makes it worse — headaches, mild disorientation, a persistent sense of being watched. Push through the discomfort to stay on the trail when others would turn back.

Preparation bonus: If the party got detailed directions from the surviving peacekeeper in Phase 1 (specifically, if they asked about landmarks and terrain features), reduce all DCs by 1.

Complications on failure:

- The party follows the wrong drainage channel and wastes an hour searching a dead-end ravine. Lose time — if it matters narratively, this means they arrive at the dump site closer to dusk.
- A party member loses their footing on a loose scree slope. **Athletics D3** to catch themselves; on a failure, they take 3 damage from the fall and are Prone at the bottom.
- The party blunders into the Fog-Touched Beast's hunting ground. If combat occurs at the dump site later, the beast has already spotted them — it does not arrive as a flanker but is present from the start, lurking at the top of the east slope.

Pacing: This challenge should take 5–10 minutes of real play time. Describe each stretch briefly — a fork in the terrain, a choice of direction, a moment of doubt — call for the check, narrate the result, and move on. If the party has the preparation bonus, this should resolve in two quick checks and feel rewarding. If they do not, the third stretch gives them one more chance without dragging.

If the party is backtracking a trail from the ritual site, skip this challenge entirely — the trail is clear and consistent.

The Scene

The ravine lies in a fold of the Weald's foothills where a seasonal stream has cut a channel through soft stone. It runs roughly northeast-to-southwest, forty feet long and twenty feet across at its widest point, narrowing at both ends. The walls are uneven — fifteen feet deep on the north side where the stone is sheer, sloping to eight feet on the south side where the ground has eroded into

a rough grade. The seasonal stream has left a shallow drainage channel running the length of the floor, dry in summer but muddy after rain.

You smell it before you see it. Not rot, exactly — something drier, more clinical. The trail leads to a shallow ravine screened by deadfall and brush. Someone has piled cut branches over the opening. It is not a natural formation.

Beneath the screen, you find the bodies.

There are seven of them, laid out in a rough row along the west wall, partially covered by a weathered tarp weighed down with stones. They are not decomposed — they are *desiccated*, as if every drop of vitality has been wrung from them. Their skin is paper-thin, stretched tight over bone. Their eyes are open, and their expressions are not peaceful. They look as though something was pulled from them, and they felt every moment of it.

The most recent body is perhaps a week old. The oldest could be months. Whatever has been done to them has slowed the normal process of decay to almost nothing.

Terrain Features

The following features are relevant for the combat encounter and for drawing a map of the location.

- **Deadfall screen (southwest entry):** Cut branches and brush piled over the ravine's southwest opening, where the trail from Keshto arrives. Provides cover and blocks line of sight from outside. Moving through it costs 1 extra square of movement. A character can spend 1 AP to pull the screen aside, clearing the entry.
- **East slope game trail:** A narrow animal track descends the east wall of the ravine in a switchback. It is the route the Fog-Touched Beast uses to enter the area. A character on the game trail has elevation over the ravine floor (advantage on ranged attacks downward, disadvantage on melee from below). The trail is narrow — only one Medium creature can occupy a given section.
- **Drainage channel:** A shallow, muddy channel running the length of the ravine floor. Counts as difficult terrain. Characters who are knocked Prone in the channel are also Slowed (save ends) from the clinging mud.
- **Rocky outcrops (north ridgeline):** Tumbled boulders along the top of the north wall provide full cover and a vantage point overlooking the ravine. Climbing up requires 2 squares of movement or an **Athletics D2** check to scramble up quickly (1 square).
- **Body row (west wall):** The seven bodies lie in a rough line along the base of the west wall, covered by a tarp. The area around the bodies is difficult terrain (uneven ground, loose stones, the tarp itself). This is where the soul residue hazard is centred.
- **Northeast cairn:** A small pile of stones marks where a faint trail exits the ravine to the northeast, toward the ritual site. Šauhahten built this to mark the path for himself. It is not hidden — just unremarkable unless you know what to look for.
- **Dense brush (north slope):** Thick undergrowth on the slope below the north ridgeline. Provides concealment but not cover. Moving through costs 1 extra square.

Investigating the Scene

- **Occultism D3:** These bodies have had their souls extracted — not merely killed, but *emptied*. Whatever animating force a living person possesses, it has been drawn out by deliberate means. This is not the work of a predatory creature or a natural Fog phenomenon. Someone did this with knowledge and intention.
- **Medicine D4 or Alchemy D4:** The bodies show no signs of conventional violence — no wounds, no poison, no disease. The desiccation is not physical dehydration but a side effect of the soul extraction: the body collapses inward once the animating principle is removed. The process is clean, almost surgical. Whoever did this has performed it many times.
- **Investigate D3:** The disposal is methodical. The bodies were carried here, not dragged — there are no drag marks, but there are faint footprints (a single set, returning on the same path each time). The ravine was chosen deliberately: screened from casual observation, far enough from Keshto to avoid discovery, but accessible from a specific direction. The perpetrator comes, deposits a body, and leaves.
- **Awareness D4:** There is a trail leading away from the ravine in a direction *different* from Keshto — northeast, deeper into the Weald. The trail is faint but consistent: the same path used repeatedly. This leads to the ritual site. The cairn at the ravine's northeast end confirms it — someone marked this path deliberately.

What this site alone tells the party:

- Souls have been extracted from these people.
- The perpetrator is methodical and has done this many times.
- The bodies were brought here post-mortem — this is disposal, not the site of the killings.
- A trail leads deeper into the Weald.

What requires both sites:

- The full scope of the operation.
- The method (alchemical, Mortefactor-derived).
- The fact that neither site is where the perpetrator *lives*.

Field Encounter

Not all the bodies in the row are still. The Fog boundary's proximity and the residual energy left behind by imperfect soul extraction have done something to two of the older corpses. They have not been deliberately reanimated — Šauhahten does not know they have risen, and would not care if he did. The Fog seeped in, found empty vessels, and filled them with just enough to make them move.

When to trigger this encounter: The husks animate when the party enters the ravine and approaches the bodies, or when anyone touches or closely examines one of the corpses (i.e. when a character attempts one of the investigation checks above). If the party is standing near the body row when the husks rise, they are within melee range — this is deliberate. The moment should be shocking.

If you prefer a less sudden start, have the party notice subtle movement under the tarp before the husks fully animate — an **Awareness D3** check to spot it. Characters who succeed are not surprised. Characters who fail (or who were not looking) are surprised for the first round.

Combat: The Risen Dead

Encounter composition (party of 4): 2 Soulless Husks (T1 Minion) + 1 Fog-Touched Beast (T1 Standard). Adjust by adding or removing 1 husk for larger or smaller parties.

The husks rise from the body row. The beast arrives at the top of the east slope game trail at the start of round 2, drawn by the noise and movement. If the party blundered into its territory during the tracking challenge, the beast is already present when combat begins — it is crouched in the dense brush on the north slope.

See the Appendix for stat blocks.

Tactical advice: This is likely the party's first combat in the adventure. Run it honestly but simply.

The husks shamble toward the nearest living creature and attempt to Grab. They do not coordinate, do not flank, and do not retreat. They are not Šauhahten's controlled servants — they are empty things driven by residual Fog energy. Their movements are jerky and wrong.

The beast is a predator, not a tactician. It uses Pounce to close distance from the game trail, targeting whoever is isolated or already Grabbed by a husk. It flees if reduced below half HP — down the game trail and into the Weald.

Terrain matters:

- A character Grabbed by a husk in the drainage channel is also Slowed (mud).
- The deadfall screen limits escape routes until cleared.
- The rocky outcrops on the north ridgeline offer a defensible position for ranged characters — but climbing up takes movement.
- The body row area is difficult terrain, making it hard to manoeuvre while the husks are rising around you.

XP: 7 per Husk + 15 for the Beast = 29 total (for 2 Husks and 1 Beast).

Narrative beat: This fight should feel *wrong*. The husks are the people the party was sent to find. Their faces are recognisable — the missing farmer, the forager's spouse. If the party found the peacekeeper's description of the missing in Phase 1, one of the husks matches someone on the list.

The party is fighting the dead they came to avenge. Let the moment land. Do not rush past it for the sake of initiative order.

Hazard: Soul Residue

The soul extraction process is not perfectly clean. Fragments of the victims' essence linger in and around the bodies — not enough to constitute a soul, but enough to react when disturbed. This is not a trap Šauhahten set. It is a byproduct he either does not know about or does not care about.

When to trigger: The residue discharges when a character closely examines the bodies (any of the Medicine, Alchemy, or Occultism checks above) or when the last husk is destroyed and its animating energy dissipates back into the remains. Use whichever trigger produces the better dramatic moment — during the investigation if you want to interrupt a quiet scene with a jolt, or after the combat if you want a final punctuation mark.

This hazard triggers **once**. After it discharges, the residue is spent.

Effect: Burst 2 centred on the body row. Every character in the area must resist with **Grit D3**. On a failure, they take 4 psychic damage and are Dazed until the end of their next turn. On a success, they feel a sharp wave of anguish but shake it off — no damage, no condition.

Narrative: A character who fails the resist does not simply take damage. For a searing instant, they experience a fragment of what the victims felt: being restrained, something cold and precise pulling at the core of who they are, a moment of absolute terror as they realise what is happening, and then — nothing. Emptiness. The flash passes, leaving a headache and the certain knowledge that these people were *aware* when it happened.

A character who succeeds feels the same anguish at a remove — like hearing a scream from another room. Unpleasant, but they can push through it.

System lesson for this location: The dump site teaches three things.

First, **tracking and exploration** — the skill challenge demonstrates that reaching a destination can itself be a meaningful obstacle, and that preparation (talking to the peacekeeper) has mechanical payoff.

Second, **combat fundamentals** — the encounter with the husks and the beast introduces initiative, terrain, conditions (Grabbed, Slowed), and the emotional weight of fighting things that used to be people.

Third, **environmental hazards** — the soul residue discharge teaches that not all threats are creatures, that supernatural phenomena have mechanical teeth, and that the consequences of the villain's work extend beyond the immediate crime. If the party skips the investigation and focuses only on the combat, the hazard still fires — gently redirect them to the bodies and what they imply.

4

THE RITUAL SITE

Where the souls are taken

The ritual site is where Šauhahten performs the soul extractions. It is a mundane, grim location — a cave in a rocky outcrop, screened by dense undergrowth. The ugly work happens in an ugly place; the refined alchemy happens elsewhere.

Getting There

The party can reach the ritual site by following the trail from the dump site (**Awareness D3** to pick it up, or automatic if they succeeded on the Awareness D4 check at the dump site), or by following the peacekeeper's directions into the area and exploring (**Investigate D3**).

The Fog is thicker here. Not Dense — not yet — but present in a way it was not at the dump site. Wisps of it curl along the ground, pooling in depressions. The vegetation is wrong: bleached ferns, bark peeling in spirals, a smell like ozone and old copper. Something has been drawing Fog to this place, or the Fog has been drawn to what is happening here.

Fog exposure: The ritual site is close enough to the Fog boundary that the effects are noticeable. Mortal characters who spend more than an hour here should begin to feel uneasy — headaches, a sense of being watched, mild disorientation. This is not yet mechanically dangerous (Dense Fog exposure requires sustained presence), but it should feel threatening. Deathless characters are less affected but may notice the Fog responding to the site in unusual ways — eddying toward the cave mouth, thickening when they approach the ritual circle.

The Scene

The cave mouth is low and narrow, screened by brush that has been cut and replaced many times. Inside, the space opens into a rough chamber perhaps fifteen feet across. The stone floor has been swept clean, and you can see why: it is covered in scoring.

Concentric circles have been carved into the rock, filled with a residue that catches the light — pale, faintly luminescent. At the centre of the circles, iron stakes have been driven into the stone. The stakes are fitted with restraints. There are old stains on the restraints that do not need explanation.

Along the cave walls, crude shelves hold alchemical apparatus: glass vessels, copper tubing, a distillation rig too heavy to move easily. Some of the vessels still contain residue — a pale, oily substance that seems to move when you are not looking directly at it. The Fog curls into the cave and pools around the ritual circle, as if drawn to it.

This place has been used many times.

Investigating the Scene

- **Alchemy D4:** The residue in the ritual circles and the vessels is the byproduct of a sophisticated extraction process. This is not crude hedge-magic — it is disciplined laboratory technique adapted for field conditions. The apparatus is improvised but competent. Whoever built this knows what they are doing.
- **Occultism D4:** What is being extracted here is the soul itself — not life force, not magical energy, but the animating principle that distinguishes a person from a body. This is *not necromancy*. Necromancy manipulates the boundary between life and death; this process bypasses that boundary entirely, treating the soul as a substance to be distilled. The distinction is critical: it narrows the field of suspects dramatically.
- **Investigate D3:** The site has been used repeatedly over months. The scoring in the stone floor shows layers of ritual circles, each slightly refined from the last — the perpetrator is iterating, improving the process. The restraints have been used at least a dozen times. The volume matches the number of missing persons from Keshto.
- **Awareness D3:** A trail leads from the cave toward the dump site (if not already found). A second trail leads in a *third* direction — southwest, away from both the dump site and Keshto. This trail goes cold after a few hundred yards: the perpetrator has deliberately obscured it, brushing away tracks and using Fog cover. Whatever is at the end of that trail, finding it will require different information.
- **Occultism D5 or Alchemy D5:** The ritual technique is recognisable to anyone with specific knowledge. The circle geometry, the extraction methodology, the treatment of the soul as an alchemical substance — this is derived from Mortefactor research. Not standard Mortefactor practice, but an extension or perversion of techniques developed by the Most Ancient and Noble Order.

This last check is the pivotal clue that sends the party back to Keshto Village. If no one in the party can make this check, provide the information through other means: a symbol carved into the cave wall that matches Mortefactor iconography (recognisable with **Occultism D3** or **Lore D3**), or a discarded journal page with technical notes in a scholarly hand that references "the Order's foundations."

The adventure *requires* the party to make the Mortefactor connection. Do not let it hinge on a single high-DC check.

What both sites together tell the party:

- The full scope of the operation: at least eleven victims, extracted over months, with increasing frequency.
- The method is alchemical and scholarly — not bestial, not divine, not necromantic.
- The perpetrator is methodical, skilled, and iterating.
- Neither the dump site nor the ritual site is where the perpetrator lives. They come, work, and leave.
- The technique is Mortefactor-derived — this sends the party back to Keshto to pull on the faction thread.

System lesson for this location: Exploration in hazardous terrain. The ritual site is the party's introduction to Fog proximity, environmental awareness, and the idea that the world beyond the Clears is actively dangerous. Use the Fog to create atmosphere and mild pressure, but do not punish the party mechanically for being here — save that for later adventures when they venture deeper.

5

THE FAERIE RUIN

Beneath the old shrine

The Faerie ruin northeast of Keshto Village is the site of Šauhahten's hidden laboratory. The party may have visited the surface level during Phase 1, finding nothing suspicious. Now, armed with the Mortefactor tracker's cipher and the knowledge of what lies beneath, they return with purpose.

This chapter covers the laboratory dungeon and the climactic confrontation with Šauhahten. It is designed for sessions 6 through 8 of the adventure.

Layer 1: Getting In

The standing stones look different now that you know what to look for. The moss patterns are not random — they trace lines that were carved long before the moss grew. The resonance you felt on your first visit is not faded power; it is contained *power, held in check by the very structure of the shrine.*

The hidden entrance to the laboratory is built into the shrine's foundation. It requires a Faerie resonance cipher to open — a specific sequence of interactions with the standing stones that causes the foundation to shift, revealing a stairway descending into darkness.

- **With the tracker's partial cipher: Occultism D4** to complete the sequence and open the entrance. The tracker's information fills most of the gaps; the party needs to intuit the rest.
- **Without the cipher: Occultism D6**. Possible but very difficult. Requires the character to read the Faerie resonance directly and reconstruct the sequence from first principles.
- **With Šauhahten's notes from the ritual site:** If the party found technical notes at the ritual site that reference the cipher, reduce the DC by 1.

Failure state: If the party cannot open the entrance, the Mortefactor tracker can provide additional guidance — but at a cost. He supplies the missing cipher elements in exchange for the party's agreement to recover the research for the Mortefactors. If the party already agreed to this, he provides the help freely. If they refused, he offers again with more urgency. This is a concrete hook for future adventures: the party owes the Mortefactors a faction favour.

If the party refuses the tracker's help *and* cannot make the check, the tracker opens the entrance himself. He is not willing to let Šauhahten continue his work simply because the party is proud. The favour is owed regardless.

The party cannot brute-force the entrance. If they try to dig, smash, or blast their way through the shrine's foundation, describe the Faerie stone resisting mundane force — it absorbs impacts, flows back into shape, disperses energy harmlessly. This is deliberate: it teaches the party that preparation and information have mechanical payoff, and that not every obstacle yields to violence.

Layer 2: The Undead Sentries

The stairway descends into a corridor of worked stone — Faerie construction, old beyond reckoning, but repurposed. The first chamber the party enters has been converted into a guard post.

The stairway opens into a vaulted corridor of pale stone, carved with patterns that seem to shift at the edge of your vision. The air is cold and still. Šauhahten has hung alchemical lanterns at intervals — they cast a sickly yellow light that makes everything look jaundiced.

At the far end of the corridor, shapes move. They shuffle in a slow patrol pattern, back and forth across the width of the passage. As your light reaches them, you see what they are.

They are people. Or they were. Their skin is stretched tight, their eyes are open and empty, and they move with the mechanical repetition of something that has been wound up and set in motion. They are the same as the bodies at the dump site — but these ones are walking.

- **Awareness D2:** Characters who visited the dump site recognise the condition of the bodies immediately. These are the same husks — soulless, desiccated, reanimated. The dark implication is immediate: Šauhahten extracts the souls, then repurposes the bodies as guards.

This is a narrative payoff, not a mechanical one. The recognition should feel uncomfortable. The party is fighting the people they came to save — or at least, the shells of those people. Let the moment land before rolling initiative.

Combat: Soulless Husks

Encounter composition (party of 4): 4 Soulless Husks (T1 Minion), or 2 Soulless Husks (T1 Minion) and 1 Fog-Touched Beast (T1 Standard) if Šauhahten has captured and bound a Fog creature as an additional guard.

See the Appendix for the Soulless Husk stat block.

Tactical advice: The husks are mindless. They do not use tactics, flanking, or focus fire. They attack the nearest living creature and attempt to Grab targets, holding them in place for other husks to attack. They do not retreat, do not call for help, and do not adapt to the party's strategy.

This fight should feel grim but manageable. The husks are speed bumps, not a serious threat. Their purpose is to introduce the party to combat in the dungeon, establish the tone, and begin the alert level clock.

XP: 7 per Husk (28 total for 4, or 29 for 2 Husks + 1 Beast).

Layer 3: Fey Illusions and Barriers

Beyond the guard post, the ruin's Faerie nature reasserts itself. The corridors here respond to Šauhahten's Mirror birthright in ways they would not for anyone else: the space is subtly wrong.

The corridor branches. Both branches look identical. The left one feels *wrong — or does the right one? You are not sure. The patterns in the stone have shifted. You are fairly certain the corridor did not branch when you looked at it a moment ago.*

This layer is a stretch-based skill challenge, not a combat encounter. The party must navigate through Faerie illusions: false passages, rooms that loop, doors that are not there, walls that are.

Running the Skill Challenge

The party makes a series of group checks to navigate the illusions. Each stretch represents a section of the ruin that must be puzzled through.

Number of stretches: Start with 3. Each failed check adds 1 additional stretch (to a maximum of 5 total). Each successful check reduces the remaining stretches by 1.

Available checks (each stretch, choose one):

- **Occultism D4:** See through the illusion directly by reading the Faerie magic that sustains it.
- **Awareness D5:** Notice spatial inconsistencies — a corridor that is longer on the inside than the outside, a room with four walls but five corners.
- **Investigate D4:** Apply logic and mapping to identify which passages are real. Slower but reliable.

Preparation bonus: If the party has information from Phase 3 — the tracker's cipher knowledge, Mortefactor intel on Faerie ruin architecture, or Šauhahten's notes — reduce all DCs in this section by 2.

Complications on failure:

- The party loops back to a previous room, losing time.
- One or more party members become briefly separated (rejoin after 1 stretch).
- A false passage triggers a minor hazard: a pit, a Faerie ward that deals minor damage to Ward, or a disorienting flash.

Pacing: This layer should take 15–20 minutes of real play time, not more. Describe each stretch briefly, call for the check, narrate the result, and move on. If it starts to drag, let the next success automatically clear the remaining stretches. The point is to demonstrate that preparation matters and that not every obstacle is a fight — not to exhaust the party with a skill gauntlet.

Not solved by fighting. If the party attempts to hack through walls, smash illusions, or force their way through, describe the Faerie stone reforming behind them, the corridor resetting, the illusion reasserting itself. Violence here is not just ineffective — it is counterproductive, as it may alert Šauhahten (see Alert Level below).

Layer 4: The Alchemical Monstrosity

Beyond the illusions, the party reaches the inner chambers of the ruin. A large, vaulted hall separates them from the laboratory proper. It is not empty.

The hall is vast — far larger than it should be, given the size of the ruin above. The ceiling disappears into shadow. The Faerie lanterns here are brighter, and you wish they were not.

Something is moving in the hall. It is the size of a cart horse but shaped like nothing that has ever lived. Its body is a mass of fused tissue — pale, translucent, shot through with veins of luminescent fluid. It has too many limbs, and they do not all bend in the same direction. Where it touches the stone, the stone *hisses*.

It turns toward you. It does not have a face, exactly, but it knows you are there.

ALCHEMICAL MONSTROSITY — T2 STANDARD

CONSTRUCT | ALCHEMICAL | LARGE

HP 55 | **Armor** 7 | **Ward** 6 | **Evasion** 3 | **AP** 4 | **Speed** 3

Martial 8 | **Stamina** 7 | **Grit** 6

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated, Poisoned

Regeneration: The Monstrosity recovers 5 HP at the start of each of its turns. This regeneration ceases if the Monstrosity takes fire damage or is affected by an effect that specifically prevents healing.

Heavy Slam — 2 AP

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 8+2D8

On hit: Target is knocked Prone.

Sweeping Strike — 2 AP

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, all enemies within 2 squares

Damage: 5+1D10

XP: 25

This creature is beyond a Tier 1 party's ability to fight head-on. Its HP, Armor, and damage output are deliberately overtuned. A straight fight will result in serious casualties. The intended solutions are:

- **Lure it into a trap:** The hall contains a partially collapsed section (see Environmental Features below). The monstrosity can be baited into the collapse zone and buried.
- **Seal it behind a barrier:** A Faerie ward in the hall can be reactivated with an **Occultism D4** check, creating a barrier that the monstrosity cannot cross.
- **Use the architecture:** A narrow passage at the far end of the hall is too small for the monstrosity to follow. The party can sprint for it.
- **Simply run past:** The monstrosity is large but not fast (Speed 3). A party that moves decisively can reach the far exit before it closes the distance.

Award full XP (25) regardless of whether the party fights, bypasses, or traps the monstrosity. State this to the players if they ask.

Environmental Features

- **Collapsed section:** The northeast corner of the hall shows signs of structural damage — cracked pillars, loose rubble, a ceiling that sags. A strong impact or an **Athletics D4** check to knock out a support pillar will bring the ceiling down in a 3-square area. Anything caught beneath takes 20 damage (no defense roll) and is Restrained until dug out.
- **Faerie ward:** A circle of standing stones in the centre of the hall. The stones are inert but intact. **Occultism D4** (D2 with the tracker's cipher) reactivates the ward, creating a barrier of shimmering light across a 4-square line. The monstrosity will not cross the barrier. The barrier lasts for 10 minutes — more than enough time.
- **Narrow passage:** The far exit from the hall is a natural fissure in the ruin's wall, perhaps three feet wide. Medium and smaller creatures can squeeze through easily. The monstrosity cannot follow. A Large character must succeed on an **Athletics D3** check to squeeze through quickly.

Layer 5: Šauhahten

The passage beyond the hall opens into the laboratory proper: a series of interconnected chambers carved from Faerie stone, equipped with alchemical apparatus far more sophisticated than the crude rig at the ritual site.

Alert Level

How much warning Šauhahten has depends on the party's approach through the dungeon. Track this as a simple three-tier system:

- **Quiet:** The party opened the entrance cleanly, dispatched the husks quickly and without excessive noise, navigated the illusions without triggering complications, and bypassed the monstrosity without a prolonged fight. **Šauhahten is mid-work when they arrive.** He is surprised, and the laboratory is fully intact.
- **Moderate:** The party made some noise — a prolonged fight with the husks, a few failed stretches in the illusions, or a direct engagement with the monstrosity. **Šauhahten is aware and preparing.** He has stopped work and is waiting. He is not surprised, but the laboratory is intact.
- **Loud:** The party fought the husks at length, struggled with the illusions, fought the monstrosity directly, or otherwise spent a long time in the dungeon. **Šauhahten is destroying notes when they arrive.** He has had time to burn his most sensitive research and conceal or destroy key materials. The laboratory is partially dismantled — reduced loot, and some research is unrecoverable.

The Laboratory

The laboratory is beautiful in a way that makes your skin crawl. Glassware of extraordinary precision lines the walls. A distillation array — copper, silver, and crystal — dominates the central chamber, its tubes and vessels arranged with an artisan's care. Journals are stacked neatly on a writing desk. Everything is clean, ordered, and purposeful.

And in a recess at the back of the room, sealed glass vessels glow with a pale, shifting light. Each vessel contains a luminous substance that moves like something alive. These are the souls.

The Conversation

If the alert level is Quiet or Moderate, Šauhahten speaks before fighting.

He is standing by the distillation array when you enter. Tall, even for a Mirror — the fey shimmer of an Echo plays across his features, making his expression difficult to read. He does not reach for a weapon. He does not look afraid.

"Ah," he says, as if you are guests who have arrived slightly ahead of schedule. "I had wondered when someone would come. Please — do not touch anything. Some of these compounds are volatile, and I would hate for anyone to be hurt unnecessarily."

He gestures to the laboratory around him with the careful pride of a craftsman showing his workshop.

"I assume you are here about the disappearances. I understand why that would concern people. I would like to explain, if you will let me. What I am doing here is important — more important than you know, and certainly more important than the lives it has cost. I know how that sounds. I ask only that you hear me out before you decide."

Šauhahten's argument, in brief: the cycle of death and rebirth is broken. Souls do not pass on — they linger, they suffer, they are consumed by the Fog. Prima Materia is the key to restarting the cycle. Yes, the process requires the rendering down of souls. Yes, it is terrible. But the alternative — an eternity of suffering for every mortal who dies — is worse. He has done the calculus. A few dozen lives now to save every soul that will ever exist.

He is calm, articulate, and genuinely believes this. He is not lying and he is not performing. He has spent decades convincing himself, and his conviction is unshakeable. He is also wrong — or at least, the voice in the Fog that guides his work has its own agenda. But *he* does not know that.

Let the party respond. Let them argue, question, challenge. Šauhahten has answers for everything. The conversation should feel like debating someone who is smarter than you and also insane.

The Moral Trap

If the party is tempted to agree with Šauhahten — or if a player genuinely finds his argument compelling — this is the moment to make the cost visceral.

Draw attention to the sealed vessels at the back of the room. The substance inside them *moves*. If a character examines them closely (**Occultism D2**), they realise: those are not distilled souls in the abstract. Those are *people*. Aware, trapped, and suffering. The extraction does not kill them cleanly — it suspends them in a state of conscious dissolution.

If the party still agrees with Šauhahten after this, the Mortefactor tracker (if he accompanied them) or Merzaghaal (who will have sent scouts to watch the shrine entrance) intervenes. The adventure does not allow the party to become complicit in soul extraction — but it does allow the moment of temptation, and that moment should feel real.

Combat

When the conversation ends — either because the party attacks, threatens the laboratory, or Šauhahten realises they will not be persuaded — combat begins.

ŠAUHAHTEN, THE MAD ALCHEMIST — T1 BOSS

DEATHLESS | MIRROR | HUMANOID

HP 55 | **FP** 30 | **Armor** 6 | **Ward** 5 | **Evasion** 3 | **AP** 5 | **Speed** 3

Arcane 7 | **Martial** 5 | **Potential** 6 | **Stamina** 5 | **Grit** 5

Immunities: Dominated

Desperate Fury: While below half HP, Šauhahten gains +1d on all attack rolls and his Evasion is reduced by 1 (to 2).

Alchemical Bolt — 2 AP

Ranged 10, Arcane vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 5+1D8

Šauhahten hurls a volatile alchemical compound that detonates on impact.

Soul Siphon — 3 AP

Ranged 8, Arcane vs Ward, single target

Damage: 6+1D12

On hit: Šauhahten heals HP equal to half the damage dealt.

A tendril of pale light connects Šauhahten to the target, drawing vitality from them. Mortefactor technique.

Fey Displacement — 1 AP (Reaction)

Trigger: Šauhahten is hit by an attack.

Šauhahten teleports up to 3 squares. Once per round.

His Mirror nature allows him to step briefly between reflections.

Distillation Overload — 3 AP

Burst 2 within 8, Arcane vs Evasion

Damage: 10+2D8

Šauhahten destabilizes one of his alchemical apparatuses, causing it to violently discharge. This ability is only available while the distillation array in the laboratory is intact. Each use visibly damages the equipment.

XP: 60

Destructible Targets

The victory condition is not killing Šauhahten — it is destroying the laboratory. The following targets can be destroyed during combat:

- **The distillation array** (central chamber): The heart of the operation. Destroying it requires 2 AP and an **Athletics D3** check (smashing) or any attack that deals 10+ damage to it. When destroyed, Šauhahten loses access to Distillation Overload and his composure cracks visibly. He gains +1d on attacks but suffers –1d on all resist checks for the remainder of the fight.
- **The research journals** (writing desk): Burning or destroying them requires 1 AP. This is the information the Mortefactor tracker wants. If the party promised to recover the research, destroying the journals breaks that promise. If the journals survive, the tracker claims them.
- **The soul vessels** (back recess): Breaking the sealed vessels releases the trapped souls. This requires 1 AP per vessel (there are three). Released souls dissipate with an expression that might be gratitude. Šauhahten reacts with genuine anguish — not for the people, but for the lost material.
- **The reagent stockpile** (side chamber): Alchemical supplies accumulated over months. Destroying them requires 2 AP and is messy — volatile compounds create a burst of chemical fire (**Burst 1, 6 damage, Evasion negates**) centred on the stockpile. This represents the bulk of the recoverable loot.

Track which targets are destroyed during the fight. Each one the party destroys reduces the available loot (see Appendix) but furthers the mission objective. The adventure's victory condition is destroying *enough* of the laboratory that Šauhahten cannot resume his work here — at minimum, the distillation array and the reagent stockpile. Destroying everything is total victory. Destroying nothing is failure even if Šauhahten is defeated, because he will return.

Šauhahten's Behaviour in Combat

Šauhahten fights to defend his work, not to kill the party. His priorities:

1. **Protect the distillation array.** He positions himself between the party and the array. If they attack it, he focuses fire on whoever is closest to it.
2. **Use Distillation Overload early.** The array is his most powerful weapon and he knows the party will try to destroy it. He uses it aggressively while it lasts.
3. **Fey Displacement to maintain distance.** Šauhahten prefers range. He uses his reaction teleport to escape melee and reposition.
4. **Soul Siphon to sustain.** His self-healing keeps him in the fight. He targets whoever has the lowest Ward.

Personality shift: As the laboratory is destroyed around him, Šauhahten's calm cracks. Track the number of destructible targets the party has destroyed:

- **0–1 destroyed:** Composed. Cold. He fights with clinical precision and speaks between attacks. "You do not understand what you are doing."
- **2 destroyed:** The mask slips. His voice rises. His attacks become more aggressive (use Desperate Fury even if above half HP, if the distillation array is destroyed). "You are condemning *every soul that will ever die* to an eternity in the Fog!"
- **3–4 destroyed:** Full grandiose narcissistic rage. He abandons tactics, attacks the nearest enemy, and screams about being the only one who *understands*. "I am the only one! The only one who sees! And you — you *insects* — you would destroy the only hope this world has ever had!"

Šauhahten is Deathless. He cannot be permanently killed. If the party defeats him in combat, he dies and will reincorporate at his soul anchor in a few days. The adventure ends with a victory — the laboratory is destroyed, the research is lost or recovered, and Šauhahten is set back by years or decades. But he *will* return.

This is both a dramatic moment and a system lesson. Deathless means Deathless. The party has won the battle, not the war. Make sure this lands: when Šauhahten falls, describe the moment with weight. He does not simply die — a Mirror's death has the quality of a shattered reflection, light fracturing and scattering. And then it is over, and the laboratory is quiet, and the party knows he will be back.

Aftermath

With Šauhahten defeated and the laboratory destroyed (or captured), the adventure moves to resolution.

Salvage

What the party can recover depends on what they destroyed during the fight and the alert level when they arrived. See the Loot Table in the Appendix for specific values. In general:

- **Intact laboratory (Quiet alert):** Maximum salvage. Alchemical equipment, reagents, research materials, and the soul vessels (if not broken).
- **Partially dismantled (Loud alert):** Šauhahten destroyed his most sensitive notes. Reduced research value, but equipment and reagents remain.
- **Post-combat:** Subtract whatever the party destroyed during the fight. Equipment smashed in Distillation Overload, burned journals, shattered vessels, detonated reagents.

The Mortefactor Tracker

If the tracker accompanied the party, this is the moment of reckoning. Did the party promise to recover the research? Did they keep that promise?

- **Research recovered:** The tracker takes the journals and any intact research materials. He is satisfied. The Mortefactors owe the party goodwill — not a formal debt, but a relationship that can be called upon.
- **Research destroyed:** The tracker is disappointed but not hostile. The party chose their own path. The Mortefactors will remember this — not as a betrayal, but as a data point about the party's priorities.
- **Never agreed:** No tension. The tracker takes whatever the party does not want and departs with professional courtesy.

Contract Completion

The party returns to Keshto and reports to Merzaghaal. The Black Guard contract is fulfilled. Payment is issued (see Wealth Budget in the Introduction).

Merzaghaal is satisfied but not celebratory. He understands what "Deathless" means. Šauhahten will return. The Fog patron is still out there. This chapter is closed, but the book is not.

6

APPENDIX

Reference tables and bestiary

Bestiary

The following stat blocks are for recurring or generic creatures encountered during the adventure. Unique creatures (the Alchemical Monstrosity and Šauhahten) have their stat blocks in the Faerie Ruin chapter where they appear.

Fog-Touched Beast

A predator warped by prolonged Fog exposure. These creatures are found near the Fog boundary in the Weald's outskirts, drawn to areas of residual supernatural energy. They are aggressive but not suicidal — they flee if reduced below half HP.

FOG-TOUCHED BEAST — **T1 STANDARD**

BEAST | FOG-TOUCHED

HP 22 | **Armor** 5 | **Ward** 4 | **Evasion** 2 | **AP** 4 | **Speed** 4

Martial 6 | **Stamina** 5 | **Grit** 4

Bite — 2 AP
Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target
Damage: 4+1D8

Pounce — 2 AP
Move up to Speed, then Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target
Damage: 4+1D8
On hit: Target is Exposed (save ends).

XP: 15

Soulless Husk

The reanimated bodies of Šauhahten's victims, stripped of their souls and bound into mindless servitude. They are slow, relentless, and unsettling. They do not speak, do not retreat, and do not respond to pain.

SOULLESS HUSK — **T1 MINION**

UNDEAD | MINDLESS

HP 10 | **Armor** 5 | **Ward** 3 | **Evasion** 2 | **AP** 3 | **Speed** 2

Martial 5 | **Stamina** 4 | **Grit** 3

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated

Slam — 2 AP
Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target
Damage: 3+1D8
On hit: Target is Grabbed (save ends). While Grabbed, the Husk does not need to spend AP to maintain the grab.

XP: 7

Derelict Obliterator Drone

This Perfector war machine has been rotting in its current location for untold decades. Its armor cladding is covered in grime, steel components are rusted, and the targeting lenses are cracked. The mist reactor produces a sickly hum, and its lift arrays have long failed. Unfortunately, its cannon still works, and it still treats unknown humanoids as threats.

DERELICT OBLITERATOR DRONE — **T5 ELITE**

CONSTRUCT | DERELICT | SIZE 3

HP 200 | **FP** 80 | **Armor** 25 | **Ward** 22 | **Evasion** 0 | **AP** 4 | **Speed** 0

Marksmanship 8 | **Potential** 16 | **Grit** 12 | **Stamina** 17 | **Dodge** 0 | **Initiative** 9

Immobile: The Drone's lift array is shot. It is embedded in the ground and cannot move.

Obliterator Cannon — 2 AP
Ranged, Burst 3, range increment 80 squares
Damage: 20+2D12 Thermal; **Pen** 18
Special: The magnetic coils on this cannon are damaged. On every shot, the drone must make a save; on 0 successes or fewer, the plasma loses containment and the cannon explodes violently, destroying the drone instantly and dealing 60+6D12 damage to everything within 10 squares of it.

XP: 25

Skill Check Reference

SKILL CHECKS BY LOCATION

Location	Skill	DC	Result
Keshto (Phase 1)	Investigate	2	Disappearance timeline and geographic pattern
Keshto (Phase 1)	Influence	3	Reeve opens up about personal toll on community

Keshto (Phase 1)	Influence	2	Peacekeeper talks about what happened
Keshto (Phase 1)	Awareness	3	Peacekeeper is holding back emotion (not info)
Keshto (Phase 1)	Occultism	5	Faerie resonance unusually preserved (flavour)
Keshto (Phase 1)	Investigate	6	Someone has visited the shrine recently (very hard)
Keshto (Phase 1)	Investigate	3	Find the local who remembers Šauhahten
Dump Site	Awareness	3	Read disturbed vegetation and repeated passage (tracking)
Dump Site	Investigate	3	Reason out disposal logic to narrow search area (tracking)
Dump Site	Stamina	4	Push through rough terrain and Fog discomfort (tracking)
Dump Site	Occultism	3	Souls have been extracted from the bodies
Dump Site	Medicine/ Alchemy	4	No conventional violence; desiccation from soul removal
Dump Site	Investigate	3	Methodical disposal; bodies brought post-mortem
Dump Site	Awareness	4	Trail leading to the ritual site
Dump Site	Grit	3	Resist soul residue discharge (4 psychic, Dazed on fail)
Ritual Site	Alchemy	4	Sophisticated extraction process, disciplined technique
Ritual Site	Occultism	4	Soul extraction, not necromancy
Ritual Site	Investigate	3	Repeated use, iterating process, volume matches missing
Ritual Site	Awareness	3	Trail to dump site; second trail goes cold
Ritual Site	Occultism/ Alchemy	5	Technique is Mortefactor-derived (pivotal clue)
Keshto (Phase 3)	Influence	3	Merzaghaal shares faction intel
Keshto (Phase 3)	Awareness	4	Tracker has his own agenda
Keshto (Phase 3)	Influence	4	Negotiate terms with the tracker
Keshto (Phase 3)	Investigate	2	Find the local who remembers (reduced DC with description)
Faerie Ruin	Occultism	4	Open entrance with tracker's cipher
Faerie Ruin	Occultism	6	Open entrance without cipher
Faerie Ruin	Awareness	2	Recognise undead as dump site victims
Faerie Ruin	Occultism	4	See through Faerie illusion (per stretch)
Faerie Ruin	Awareness	5	Notice spatial inconsistency (per stretch)
Faerie Ruin	Investigate	4	Map and logic through illusions (per stretch)
Faerie Ruin	Athletics	4	Collapse pillar onto monstrosity
Faerie Ruin	Occultism	4	Reactivate Faerie ward (D2 with cipher)
Faerie Ruin	Athletics	3	Squeeze through narrow passage (Large only)
Faerie Ruin	Occultism	2	Recognise soul vessels contain aware, suffering people
Faerie Ruin	Athletics	3	Smash the distillation array

Loot Table

Values are per party, not per character. The party divides loot as they see fit.

LOOT BY LOCATION

Location	Item	Value	Notes
Dump Site	Personal effects of victims	50 ƒ	Coins, trinkets, equipment from the missing
Ritual Site	Alchemical reagents (crude)	100 ƒ	Leftover extraction byproducts, salvageable
Ritual Site	Glassware and apparatus	150 ƒ	Too heavy to carry all; party chooses what to take
Laboratory	Alchemical equipment	400 ƒ	Destroyed if distillation array smashed
Laboratory	Refined reagents	200 ƒ	Destroyed if reagent stockpile detonated
Laboratory	Research journals	300 ƒ	Tracker claims if recovered; destroyed if burned
Laboratory	Soul vessels (intact)	–	No sale value. Releasing the souls is its own reward

Laboratory	Šauhahten's personal effects	100 ƒ	Mirror-crafted items, alchemical tools, cipher notes
Maximum total		**1300 ƒ**	Everything intact, nothing destroyed
Minimum total		**200 ƒ**	Loud alert, all targets destroyed in combat
Typical total		**600–900 ƒ**	Moderate alert, some destruction

XP Summary

XP PER CHARACTER

Source	XP	Notes
Fog-Touched Beast (×1, dump site)	15	Field encounter
Soulless Husks (×2, dump site)	14	Risen dead at dump site, 7 each
Soulless Husks (×4, laboratory)	28	Laboratory Layer 2, 7 each
Alchemical Monstrosity	25	Fought or bypassed
Šauhahten	60	Laboratory Layer 5
Mission: destroy laboratory	100	Primary objective
Mission: secondary (optional)	100	E.g. recover research, confirm patron's existence
Loot XP	20–90	1 XP per 10 ƒ recovered
Total from adventure	**362–432**	**Per character**

This table covers only XP sources explicitly detailed in the adventure. Over eight sessions, characters will also earn XP from incidental encounters, additional loot, and GM-awarded story milestones. The expected total per character over the full adventure is 1500–2000 XP.

Clue Flowchart

The investigation has four threads that build toward the climax. The following shows which clues are mandatory (the adventure cannot proceed without them) and which are optional (they enrich the picture but are not required).

Thread 1: The Facts

- **Source:** Town Reeve, peacekeeper, Merzaghaal
- **Key information:** People are disappearing. Northeast. Accelerating.
- **Status:** Mandatory. The party receives this without checks.

Thread 2: The What

- **Source:** Dump site, ritual site
- **Key information:** Souls are being extracted. The method is alchemical.
- **Status:** Mandatory. Requires visiting at least one field site.
- **Fallback:** If the party visits neither site, Merzaghaal sends another search party that finds the dump site and reports back.

Thread 3: The Who

- **Source:** Ritual site (Mortefactor-derived technique) → Mortefactor Tracker → Šauhahten's identity
- **Key information:** A Mirror ex-Mortefactor named Šauhahten.
- **Status:** Mandatory. Requires the Mortefactor connection.
- **Fallback:** If the party cannot make the Occultism/Alchemy D5 check at the ritual site, provide the Mortefactor clue through alternative means (see the Ritual Site chapter).

Thread 4: The Where

- **Source:** Tracker's knowledge of Prima Materia requirements + the Faerie site's characteristics. Optionally confirmed by the local who remembers (supply routes pointing northeast toward the shrine).
- **Key information:** The laboratory is beneath the Faerie shrine.
- **Status:** Mandatory. The tracker provides this if the party cannot deduce it themselves.

Open Threads

The following plot threads are deliberately left unresolved at the end of the adventure. They are hooks for future adventures, to be developed by the GM as they see fit.

Šauhahten Will Return

He is Deathless. He will reincorporate at his soul anchor in a matter of days. The laboratory is destroyed, but his knowledge is intact. He will start over — somewhere else, with better security, and with a grudge. Whether he targets the party specifically or simply resumes his work elsewhere depends on the tone the GM wants for the campaign.

The Patron in the Fog

Šauhahten was guided by a voice in the Fog — an intelligence that offered knowledge and encouragement. The adventure deliberately leaves the patron's nature undefined. It is not what Šauhahten thinks it is. It benefits from souls being rendered down. Beyond that, the GM decides: a dead god's echo, a Faerie parasite, a Fog-born intelligence, or something else entirely.

The Mortefactor Favour

If the party accepted the tracker's help opening the laboratory entrance, they owe the Mortefactors a favour. The nature of this favour is unspecified — the Mortefactors will call it in when it serves them. This is a faction hook: it ties the party into the politics of the Most Ancient and Noble Order, for better or worse.

The Research

If the research journals survived, the Mortefactors now possess detailed notes on Prima Materia extraction. Whether they secure this knowledge responsibly or whether it creates problems of its own is a question for future adventures. If the research was destroyed, the knowledge died with the journals — but Šauhahten still remembers.